

In Company

Skills & Language for Successful Staff Meetings



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Avanti Staff_{corp.}
Language Service

In Company

Skills & language for successful staff meetings

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Introduction to *In Company*



■ About *In Company*

- **The Target:** Understand and practice how to create successful meetings.
- **The Training: 5 Points**
 1. **Theory** Understand the structure and process of successful meetings.
 2. **Language** Learn and practice the language of meetings.
 3. **Models** Study and practice the theory and language of meetings with model meeting transcripts.
 4. **Simulations** Practice the theory, structure, and language in business meeting simulations.
 5. **Feedback** Listen to the feedback about your performance in the simulations.

■ About Simulations

- The purpose of the simulations is to practice the structure, tasks and language of meetings.
 - Time window: each simulation has a time window that includes the meeting simulation and follow up feedback.
 - Everyone in the class will have an opportunity to practice all the skills for successful meetings: chairing, presenting, asking questions, and taking notes.
 - Each meeting simulation will have the same time window for the simulation and feedback.
- Preparing for & conducting simulations
 - For the first simulations in the course the chairpeople write a complete chairing script suitable for the purpose of the meeting. The chairing script includes only what the chairperson says.
 - The script should be written by hand in a notebook. Writing by hand is better than typing on a computer. Writing notes in the text is not acceptable.
 - In the first round of simulations the chairpeople should read their chairing scripts.
 - After the first simulation the chairpeople write a chairing script and practice it, but they cannot use the script in the simulation. They must chair the meeting simulations from memory.

1. The Business Meeting



■ About Business Meetings

A business meeting is a creative process in which information, questions, and ideas are exchanged, and understanding and agreements are created.

■ Two Goals of Communication: Understanding & Agreement

1. The first goal of all communication is to create understanding.
2. The ultimate goal of communication is to achieve agreement.
3. Agreement cannot exist without understanding.

■ Social Protocol of Communication

Although a business meeting focuses on business, it is a meeting of people.

People are social by nature so successful meetings always include the social exchanges that help create and maintain good relationships.

Observing the social protocol of communication is an important part of meetings.

The Social Protocol of Communication

The rules of social communication differ from culture to culture but the goal is always the same: to create understanding and harmony.

The Rules of Social Interaction consist of:

- What to do and say.
- When to do it and say it.

Examples of social protocol:

- Courteous language: “Please” and “Thank you”.
- Exchanging greetings: Greetings are always returned.
- Standing and shaking hands (or bowing) to exchange greetings.
- Listening to others while they speak and responding appropriately.

■ The Reasons for Meetings

There are two reasons to hold a meeting:

1. To share information that will benefit the people in the meeting.
2. Discuss specific issues or problem and make decisions.

■ Tasks & Structure: Creating a successful meeting

Meetings need to be efficient & effective: the staff's time is valuable: it should be well spent and productive. Knowing the tasks and structure of meetings is the first step to making them productive.

Five Tasks in a Meeting: Who does what?	
There are five important tasks that contribute to the success of a meeting:	
1. Chairperson	Systematically manages the flow of the meeting.
2. Topic Leader	Presents information for discussion.
3. Participants	Ask questions, make comments, offer proposals, discuss and evaluate the information, contribute to decisions.
4. Note Taker	Takes notes on decisions; prepares the meeting report or minutes.
5. Time Keeper	Keeps time so the meeting starts and finishes on time and each item on the agenda has the appropriate amount of time.
A Note About the Tasks In addition to chairing the meeting, the chairperson might also take notes and keep the time in small meetings. However, in a larger meeting it is better for each task to be done by a different person.	

Structure of a Meeting: What needs to be done & when?	
Successful meetings can be divided into six essential steps. Each step contributes to the success of the meeting.	
1. Warm-up	Greetings and courtesies.
2. Confirm	Confirm the purpose and goals of the meeting.
3. Issues	Review the agenda & clarify the items to be discussed.
4. Deal	Deal with the agenda item by item. Make decisions.
5. Review	Review and confirm decisions from the notes.
6. Wrap-up	Closing courtesies and appreciations.
A Note About Time The time spent on each step varies according to the situation and culture: some steps are done quickly while other steps take a long time. It is the chairperson's responsibility to guide the meeting through the six steps. See Unit 2 for the details.	

2. Chairing a Meeting



■ An Effective Chairperson

The successful meeting depends on the chairperson to take the lead and coordinate the process.

- Without a good chairperson the meeting will not be focused and it will not create good results. The participants will feel they have wasted their time.

■ The Chairperson's Tasks

The effective chairperson is like an effective manager, keeping the meeting focused on the issues, guiding the discussion toward an appropriate conclusion, and keeping to the schedule.

- When we describe the chairperson's tasks we are actually describing the structure of the meeting.
- The effective chairperson guides the meeting through the six stages in a way that is appropriate to the situation.

The chairperson must:

1. Begin by getting everyone's attention.
2. Start the meeting with greetings.
3. Confirm the purpose and goals of the meeting.
4. Confirm the issues and review the agenda and allotted time.
5. Introduce each item on the agenda.
6. Coordinate the discussion of each item on the agenda.
7. Encourage participation in questions and discussion.
8. Manage time wisely.
9. Call for breaks and restart the meeting.
10. Bring the meeting to a close:
 - Review the results of the meeting and the date of the next meeting.
 - Thank the participants.
 - Close the meeting.

■ The Agenda

The agenda is a list of items to be discussed during the meeting. It is one of the most important documents in a meeting.

- **A meeting must have an agenda**

The agenda is like a road map and helps to keep the meeting focused on the goals and on schedule.

- The items on the agenda are organized to make efficient use of time.
- The chairperson reviews the agenda before beginning discussion so all the participants can focus on the issues.
- During the meeting each item on the agenda is introduced by the chairperson, discussed by the participants and decided upon before moving on to the next item.

- **Setting the agenda**

The agenda is usually set before the meeting. In the meeting, the agenda must be reviewed before the discussion begins in order to focus the discussion.

- In other cases the agenda can be set in the meeting but before the discussion begins.
- To set the agenda the chairperson must know the purpose of the meeting and get input from others.
- In a regular staff meeting the agenda is usually the same every time.

- **Who sets the agenda?**

The type of meeting determines how the agenda is set.

- For an information meeting or training session, the agenda is set by the chairperson or trainer.
- In a team meeting the participants together decide the agenda.
- In a meeting with a client (client relations) the agenda is not so rigid – it is set and followed according the client's needs.
- In negotiation, the counterparties must equally contribute to and agree upon the agenda.
- The agenda is critical in negotiation. The party that sets the agenda controls the focus and process of the negotiation.

- **Changes and additions to the agenda**

Changes and additions to the agenda can be made at the beginning of the meeting:

- Changes are not usually made during the discussion.
- New items that come up during the discussion are often are held (or “tabled”) for the next meeting.

Vocabulary Note

“Agenda”

The agenda is a list with several items for discussion.

Never say “agenda” when you mean “item on the agenda”.

For example:

- We have three items on our agenda.
- The next item on our agenda is a report from Mr. Honma.

■ **Q&A and Discussion**

The chairperson’s second important task is to manage the discussion and questions from the participants.

- Discussion and Q&A are essential parts of a meeting.
- The chairperson creates the discussion by asking for questions from the participants and encouraging participation.
- After the participants have asked questions the chairperson can also ask questions.
- However, the chairperson should always be prepared to ask questions in order to encourage others to do so.
- The chairperson must guide the discussion toward a clear conclusion.

■ **Making Decisions**

A decision is composed of the answers to 3 essential Wh-questions:

Who is doing What, by When?

If one of the answers is missing there is no decision.

When decisions are made they must be written down.

- In a staff meeting, the note taker records the decisions and prepares the meeting minutes or report.
- With a counterparty, decisions are recorded in an M.O.U. – a memo of understanding - and provide the basis for the contract.

3. Model Meeting 1: Giving Reports

■ Model Meeting Transcript

Read and practice the model meeting transcript below.

1. Take note of how the chairperson follows the meeting structure and the language that he uses.
2. After practicing the model meeting transcript, take turns chairing your own meetings for practice.
3. There will be one short meeting simulation for each student: Each student will have a turn as chairperson and as topic leader.
4. Topic of the meetings: Meeting experience. Briefly describe the meetings you attend:
 - Who are your meetings with?
 - Why do you meet and what do you discuss?
 - How often are the meetings and how long are they?
 - What is your usual role in the meetings?
 - What meeting skills do you need to improve?
5. Use the report in the transcript as a platform for your own report. Notice the three-part structure: 1) Introduction; 2) Body; 3) Conclusion.
6. Feedback: After each meeting the other students and the instructor will offer feedback

■ Model Meeting Transcript

The Model Meeting transcript has six participants:

1. Chair: Mr. Hosei
 2. Topic Leader: Ms Honda
 3. Note Taker: Mr. Obata
- + Three Participants who ask questions: Ms Miura, Mr. Obata, & Mr. Suzuki.

Language		Notes on the Steps
Chair	Good morning everyone. I'd like to start our meeting now. Thank you all for being here. I'll be chairing our first session today.	Step 1: Warm up: Greetings & courtesies.
	As you know, this morning we are going to discuss our meeting experience. We need to report to the HR department so they can develop a new training program for meeting skills.	Step 2: Clarify the purpose & goal for the meeting.
	Did you all receive the memo dated December 2?	Confirm information.
All	Yes. / Yes, I did.	

Chair	Good. Let me just confirm the details in the memo. We will each make a brief report about our meetings, role in the meetings and the skills we need to improve. After each report we'll have time for questions and discussion. Mr. Obata will be taking notes and reporting the skills that need improvement to HR.	Step 3: <i>Review agenda & items to handle.</i>
All	Are there any questions?	<i>Confirm procedure.</i>
Chair	No. / No, not from me. Thank you.	
	Our first report will be from Mr. Ohara. Ms Honda works in the Logistics Dept. Ms Honda, if you please.	Step 4: <i>Deal with the agenda: Call on the topic leader.</i>
Honda	Thank you, Mr. Hosei. Good morning everyone. It's a pleasure to be here. As Mr. Hosei said, I work in the logistics department of our parts factory. We coordinate shipments into and out of the factory. We have meetings every Friday afternoon.	1) Introduction: <i>Courteous opening & description of the work of the department.</i>
	Our meetings usually last an hour or more. There are usually six or seven people in the meeting. They are from production and purchasing as well logistics. We review the production and shipping schedules for the following two weeks and talk about problems that might be coming up. We make routine decisions but if there is a big issue we take it to the manager after the meeting. I usually chair the meetings. I find it quite difficult to chair because some people speak too much or they speak out of turn and others don't speak at all.	2) Body: <i>Describe the meetings, procedure, role and challenges.</i>
	Sometimes the meetings take a long time and it's difficult to make clear decisions. We often have follow up e-mail or phone calls to ask questions or clarify the decisions. I really need to improve my chairing skills so I recommend that the training program focus on chairing skills. And that concludes my report. Thank you for listening.	3) Conclusion to the report.

Chair	Thank you Ms Honda. That was very interesting. Now we have time for questions. Yes, Ms Miura?	<i>Transition to Q&A.</i>
Miura	Thank you. I'd like to ask about the agenda for your meetings. Who prepares the agenda?	
Honda	Oh, we don't need an agenda because everyone knows what we're talking about.	
Miura	I see. Thank you.	
Chair	Yes, Mr. Obata?	
Obata	I have a question about wrapping up the meeting. Do you review the decisions at the end of the meeting?	
Honda	No, we don't have time to review. Besides everyone takes notes.	
Obata	Thank you.	
Chair	We have time for one more question. Yes, Mr. Suzuki?	
Suzuki	... asks his question and Ms Honda responds...	
Chair	I'm sorry, that's all the time we have for questions. Thank you everyone. Thank you for your report Ms Honda.	
	Mr. Obata, could you review the skills that need improvement, please?	Step 5: <i>Review the notes.</i>
Obata	Yes. According to my notes Ms Honda said he needed to improve his chairing skills so that his meetings are shorter and create better decisions.	
Chair	Thank you Mr. Obata. Is there anything to add?	
All	No. / No, not from me. / That seems fine.	
Chair	Good.	
	Thank you Mr. Obata. And you will report that to HR, right?	Step 6: <i>Wrap up the meeting with courtesies</i>
Obata	Yes, I will. I'll do it right after the meeting.	
Chair	Thank you very much.	
	We'll take a short break now. After our break, Ms Honda will chair, Mr. Suzuki will report, and Mr. Kanda will be taking notes. Thank you everyone. We'll start again in 10 minutes.	

- **Discussion:** How do you evaluate the quality of Ms Honda's meetings? Do you have any recommendations to improve them?

4. The Topic Leader: Short Presentations



■ The Topic Leader's presentation is a message to the audience.

The message should be clear and memorable.

- The presentation has information and ideas the listeners need in order to make decisions.

The Topic Leader should ask:

- What is my message?
- What do I want my listeners learn from my presentation?
- What do I want my listeners do?

■ Three important elements: Structure, Content, Language

In the Model Meeting transcript in Unit 3, Ms Honda followed this structure.

1. Structure: An effective presentation is organized into three parts.

1. Introduction - *Say what you're going to say.*

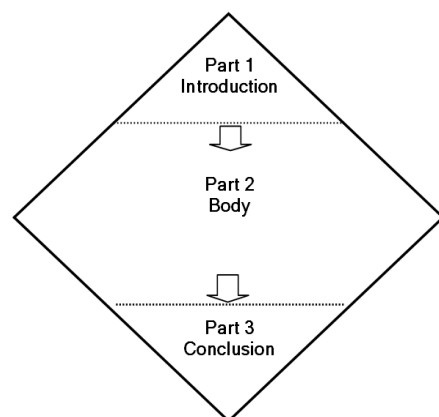
- Greet your audience.
- Get their attention.
- Introduce your theme & main points.

2. Body - *Say what you need to say.*

- Explain your ideas step by step.
- Give examples & details.
- Keep your audience interested!

3. Conclusion - *Say what you said.*

- Review your main points.
- Deliver a clear message. Be specific.
- Leave your audience thinking!



2. Content: Your presentation needs three elements.

1. **Clear Explanation:** Describe the situation, issue, or proposal.
 - Use the Wh-Questions - *Who, Where, What, When, Why, & How.*
 - Support the explanation with facts, examples, numbers, names, and details.
2. **Analysis:** Explain what the information means.
 - Why is it important?
 - Explain the costs and the benefits.
 - Without your analysis, the audience will not understand the importance of your information.
3. **Clear Message:** Your message is your clear opinion or proposal.
 - Use specific words: avoid pronouns (he, she, they, it, etc.)
 - Introduce your opinion or proposal with *I think...* or *I propose...* Don't introduce a proposal with *Let's...*
 - Without a clear message, the audience will not understand the purpose of your presentation.



3. Flag Expressions: Language for Presentations

Introduction

1. Courteous opening
2. Greet the audience
3. Give your theme
4. Give your main points

What to say...

Thank you (for the introduction), Mr. Smith.
Good evening, everybody.
Today, I am going to tell you about ...
I have three main points. First, I will talk about / explain ... (Never say, *At first* See page 29.)

Body

5. Start the body
6. Second point
7. Third point

Let me begin with my first point.
Now, I'll move on to my second point.
And that brings me to my third point.

Conclusion

8. Review
9. Your message
10. Close

In conclusion, let me review my main points
First, I explained / talked about....
I think we should ...
(Never begin your message with *Let's...*)
Thank you. (*That's all.* is used only in very informal reports)
And now, I will be happy to answer your questions.

5. The Participants: Questions & Discussion



We all think differently.

Questions help create understanding.

■ The role of the participants: Listen, think critically, and ask questions.

People have different ideas. The participants need to take an active role and share their ideas. They must listen carefully, take notes, and be prepared to ask questions, make comments, and discuss the issues on the agenda.

Questions and discussion

- are essential for a presentation. The presentation is not a success without questions from the participants.
- help to clarify, confirm, and test information. Questions help to create understanding and lead to agreement.
- at the right time save time because they overcome confusion and help to solve problems.

Gathering information

Gathering information at a meeting requires good listening skills.

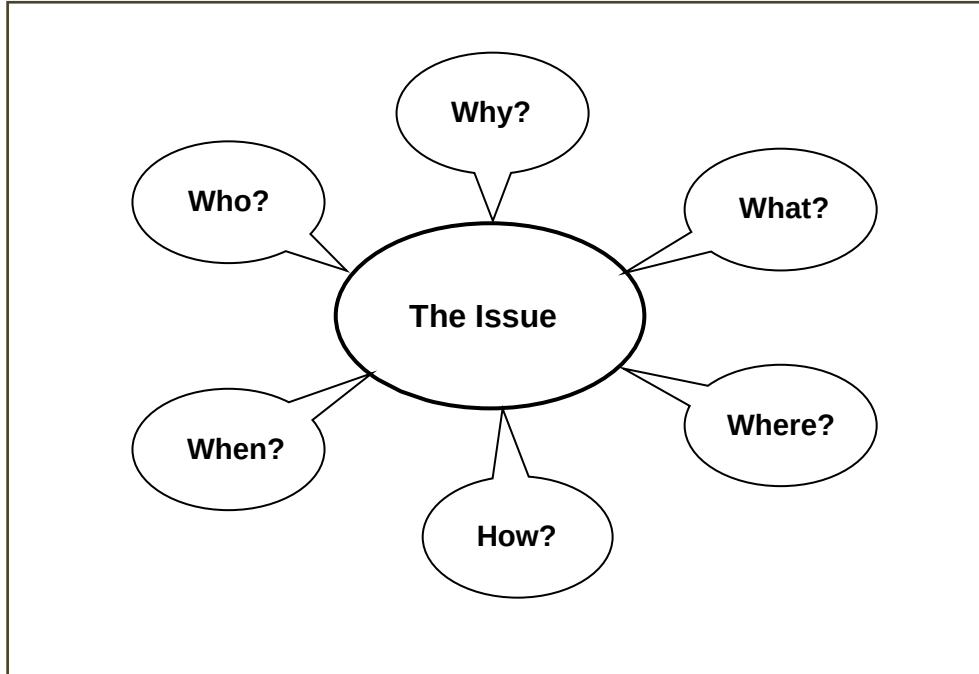
1. Look at the speaker. This is important to tell the speaker that you are listening.
2. Listen carefully and take notes in English.
3. Think about the issues.
4. Think of Wh-Questions you can ask.
5. Make notes about the things you want to ask about.

■ The Wh-Questions

Questions are essential tools to systematically analyze and organize information. They are keys that open the doors to understanding.

- You will find expressions for asking and answering questions on page 32.

Wh Questions: the Keys to Understanding & Communication



Three Important Types of Questions

Type 1 Questions Clarify and Confirm

For example: *I think you said... Is that correct?*

Type 2 Questions Get More Information

For example: *Could you tell me more about...?*

Type 3 Questions Challenge (or test) Ideas

Testing ideas and information is very important before decisions are made.

For example: *What do you think about...?*

6. Making Decisions



■ Decisions: Review Quiz

Decisions consist of three essential elements: What are they? (See page 8)

■ Coming to a decision

There are three basic ways to come to a decision in a meeting. Good decisions can be made only after exchanging and discussing differing ideas.

- 1. Consensus** All participants agree on one idea.
 - Simply agreeing with the first speaker in order to avoid conflict or save time is not consensus. There must be a full discussion.
 - Deciding by consensus maximizes the support for the decision and assures the decision will be carried out.
- 2. Majority** Most (not all) participants agree on one idea.
 - To establish a majority position a vote must be carried out, usually by a show of hands for and against. The chairperson must announce the number of votes for and against.
 - A majority vote is one way of overcoming a deadlock when consensus cannot be achieved.
- 3. Authority** One person in authority makes the decision.
 - The person in authority will listen to the discussion of differing ideas and then make a decision.
 - The authority can stop the discussion at any time even before all the ideas have been presented.

■ Guiding a discussion toward a decision

The chairperson guides the discussion in various ways and should:

- Begin the discussion by clearly stating the issue to be discussed:
 - Keep the discussion focused on the issue.
 - Set aside off-issue comments.
- This is a critical first step. Make sure all the background information is presented before discussion begins.
- Encourage discussion to find common points and points of disagreement. Make sure all the participants have an opportunity to speak.
- Summarize the points from the discussion:
 - Identify the points agreed upon.
 - Identify the points of disagreement.
- When agreement seems to appear, restate it to the participants for their attention and confirmation:
 - In your restatement, include all the details and ask for confirmation from all the participants.
 - The note taker will record your restatement.
- If there is no clear agreement, clearly state the two positions:
 - Emphasize the points of agreement and clearly state the differences.
 - Ask the participants to focus on these options.
 - Allow for new proposals that will overcome the deadlock.
- If no consensus appears, suggest...
 - Making a decision by majority vote, or
 - Leaving the issue undecided and scheduling a new meeting.

7. Model Meeting 2: Considering a Proposal



■ Model Meeting: Instructions

Read and study the model meeting transcript below and note the structure and language. Notice how the chairperson handles problems. Use this transcript as a platform for your meeting simulations.

■ Background

William Carr from McConnell Corporation's Project Planning Dept. has called a meeting of the inter-departmental bidding team to discuss a bid for the new construction project for a new client, Cates & Doyle.

There were 5 members of the bidding team at the meeting:

The team members:

- William Carr – Project Planning Dept. - Chair
- Steve Bates – Marketing Dept. - Topic Leader
- Everett Chou – Project Planning Dept. - Note Taker
- Beverly Linden – Engineering Dept.
- Michelle Tanaka – Logistics Dept.

Language		Notes on the Steps
Carr	OK everyone. We should get started now. Thank you for your time. Where are Tom Mills and Michelle Tanaka?	Step 1: Warm up: Greetings & courtesies & confirming the attendees.
Beverly	Michelle's on her way back from her meeting at Dresnel. She should be here in a few minutes.	
Carr	And what about Tom?	
Everett	He's really sick today. He had to go home early.	
Carr	That's too bad. Everett, could you take notes for us, please, and make sure Tom gets filled in on the meeting?	
Everett	Certainly.	

Carr	Thank you. All right. As you know, we're meeting to consider a proposal to bid on a project with Cates & Doyle Associates. We need to decide if we will accept the proposal and go ahead with it; or if we need more information before deciding; or if we should decline the project.	Step 2: <i>Confirming the items for discussion & procedure.</i>
	We have three items to discuss today: specifications, schedule, and feasibility. We'll start with Steve's report. We have an hour for this meeting. Does anyone have anything to add to the agenda?	Step 3: <i>Confirm the items on the agenda and the timeframe.</i>
Michelle	... Michelle Tanaka arrives at the meeting Excuse me. I'm sorry to be late. I got delayed at my meeting at Dresnel.	<i>Taking care of a late arrival and other agenda items.</i>
Carr	It's good you're here. We're just getting started. So, is there anything to add to the agenda? Yes, Michelle?	
Michelle	Yes, there are a couple of items about the Dresnel project we need to discuss.	
Carr	Are they directly related to the Cates and Doyle project?	
Michelle	No, not directly.	
Carr	Then, let's discuss them in a separate meeting, shall we? We need to focus on the C&D proposal right now.	
Michelle	OK, that makes sense.	
Carr	Thank you. OK, let's hear the report from Steve. Steve? If you please.	Step 4: <i>Calling on the topic leader.</i>
Steve	Thank you for your time everyone. As you know this is our first proposal for Cates and Doyle. The project is very large and it will be a very good contract if we win it. I'll give you a brief overview of the project and the details. I'll take your questions after my report. I have copies of the project specifications for you. Here you are. <i>(Handing out the documents)</i> C&D is a large company and they are very demanding. They want to begin operations no later than 42 months from now.	<i>Steve hands out the document when he needs them for his presentation. Not before.</i>

Beverly	Excuse me, Steve. Did you say 42 months? I don't think that's possible for us at this time. I think ...	<i>Beverly interrupts the proceedings.</i>
Carr	Sorry, Beverly, but we should hear Steve's full report first. Then we can discuss the feasibility.	<i>The chair handles the interruption & maintains the procedure.</i>
Beverly	OK.	
Carr	Please carry on, Steve.	
Steve	Thank you. So, let's look at the details. As I said, this is a very big project and the schedule is tight. I'll review the specifications and explain the schedule. I'll begin with the specifications in terms of location and capacity. OK. Please turn to page 2. According to the specifications there are	<i>Steve continues to introduce his presentation.</i>
Steve	Now, I'll move on to the schedule. Full operation will begin 42 months from now. Bids for the project must be in by the end of October and the winning bid will be announced in late January. According to ... <i>Steve continues explaining the details.</i> And that's the basic information. Thank you for listening. Now I'll take your questions.	
Carr	OK, let's open this up for discussion. What are your ideas, Michelle?	<i>The chair starts the discussion.</i>
Michelle	This sounds like an interesting project. Can you tell us about the local infrastructure?	<i>Michelle comments on the project then asks her question.</i>
Steve	Yes. The site is isolated and the local infrastructure is not very good. We'll have to upgrade the access roads and supply our own power for construction.	
Michelle	I see.	
Beverly	I think we should make a site visit as soon as possible.	<i>Beverly follows up on Steve's answer.</i>
Everett	I think so, too. We need to see the situation firsthand.	
All	Sounds like a good idea.	
Carr	OK. I'll meet with Steve later to discuss the site visit.	

Beverly	This could be a very good project for us but I'm concerned about the schedule. It could be a serious problem for us.	
Everett	I think so too.	
Carr	Everyone, what do you think?	
Michelle	I think we need to study the project schedule and our current work very carefully before making any decisions.	
All	Yes, good idea. / I think so, too.	
Carr	OK. It's agreed to study the schedule. Beverly, could you take care of that?	
Beverly	Certainly.	
... the discussion continues...		
Carr	... OK everyone, we need to finish up our meeting. Let me summarize our discussion. It seems that basically we're interested in this bid but before making a final decision we need more information, right?	Step 5: The chair closes the discussion; reviews the decisions and gets confirmation.
All	Yes. / Yes, that's right.	
Carr	OK. Everett, could you review our decisions, please?	The chair asks the note taker to read his notes.
Everett	All right. Regarding the Cates and Doyle project: We decided we are interested in bidding on this project but we're not sure if it's feasible. Mr. Carr and Steve will discuss the site visit. Beverly will study the schedule. And ...	
Carr	Thanks, Everett. Could you write up your notes by tomorrow, please?	
Everett	Yes, certainly.	
Carr	Thank you. Can we meet again next week to make our decision?	The chair arranges the next meeting and closes with courtesies and appreciation.
All	Yes.	
Carr	Everett, could you arrange the meeting with everyone and book a room, please?	
Everett	Yes, I'll take care of that.	
Carr	Good. Thank you. OK, everyone that concludes our meeting. Thank you for your time.	

■ Simulation

Conduct meeting simulations to present and decide on proposals. Follow the instructions on page 3.

■ Expressions for Meetings: Greetings, courtesies, transitions, & closing

Chairperson

- *Good afternoon, everyone. I'd like to start our meeting now.*
- *Let's begin by reviewing our agenda.*
- *There will be time after each report for questions and discussion.*
- *Our first report is from Mr. Ono.*
- *Mr. Ono, could you give us your report, please?*

Speaker

- *Thank you, Mr. Yamada.*
- *It's a pleasure to be here.*
- *This afternoon, I'll be talking about ...*
- *Thank you for your interesting report, Mr. Ono.*
- *Now, we have time for some questions. (See Vocabulary Note 1 below.)*

Participants

- *Thank you. I'd like to ask about ...*
- *I have a question about ...*
- *My question is about ...*
- *(To interrupt) May I ask a question? / Could I ask a question about this?*

Chairperson

- *We have time for one more question.*
- *I'm sorry, but that's all the time we have for discussion. We need to move on to our next speaker/item. (See Vocabulary Note 2 below.)*
- *If there are no more comments or questions, we'll move on to our next speaker/item. (See Vocabulary Note 2 below.)*
- *And now, our next speaker/ item on the agenda is ...*
- *It's time for a short break. We'll break for 10 minutes and start again at 10:30.*
- *It's time to close the meeting.*
- *Let's arrange our next meeting. It will be on Monday, September 3rd at 10:30 and it will be here, again.*
- *We've had some interesting presentations and discussion. I'd like to thank you all for your participation this afternoon.*
- *Our meeting is closed. Thank you, everyone.*

Vocabulary Notes

1: Asking questions

1. After the chair calls for questions don't say, "*May I ask a question?*" "*May I ask a question?*" is used for interrupting a speaker.
2. In the Q&A session you can say, "*I'd like to ask about...*" or "*I have a question about...*"
3. Never say, "May I have a question?" It is not correct.

2: Closing the question period

There are two reasons and different expressions for closing the question period:

1. When there is no more time for questions and discussion the chair says:
I'm sorry, but that's all the time we have for discussion. We need to move on to our next speaker/item.
2. If the participants have stopped asking questions or making comments the chair says:
If there are no more comments or questions, we'll move on to our next speaker/item.

8. Notes, Minutes, & Reports



■ Taking Notes

During a meeting the note taker records the topics of discussion and the decisions made. These notes are very important because the note taker will use them to make a record of the meeting in “minutes” or in a brief report.

■ About Minutes

1. What are minutes?

- Minutes are a brief record of a meeting’s key points.

2. What is the purpose of minutes?

- The purpose of minutes is to provide an accurate summary of the issues, proposals, discussion and decisions of a meeting.
- After minutes have been approved, they become a legal document

3. Who writes the minutes?

- Minutes are written by an authorized person, then checked and approved by the chairperson and the other people at the meeting.

■ Minutes and Reports Include -

1. Date of minutes or report.
2. Meeting date, starting time and ending time.
3. Place of the meeting.
4. Type of meeting: weekly, monthly, annual, regular, special.
5. Officers of the meeting: chairperson, note taker.
6. Participants and their status; late arrivals & early departures.
7. Agenda. Attach a copy.
8. Proposals and Reasoning.
9. Agreements & Decisions: Be specific. Record – Who will do what by when?
10. Items that were tabled. They were on the agenda but not dealt with.
11. Reports can include the note taker’s personal observations and comments. Minutes do not.

■ Three Steps for Writing Minutes and Reports

1. Before the Meeting

- Get a list of the people expected at the meeting.
- Get a copy of the agenda.
- Know the purpose of the meeting.

2. During the Meeting

- Check off attendance as people arrive or pass around a sheet for the participants to write their names.
- Note the time the meeting begins.
- Write down suggestions, proposals, recommendations and motions (and who made them), and the decisions (Who is doing what by when).
- Make note of any proposals for later discussion.
- Don't try to write down every comment - just the main ideas.
- Note the ending time of the meeting.

3. After the Meeting

- Write the minutes or report as soon as possible while your memory is still fresh.
- Write in plain simple English in short sentences.
- Follow the format of previous minutes or reports.
- Report the discussion and decisions accurately.
- In a report, if you express an opinion explain it simply and clearly.
- Attach a copy of the agenda.
- For big meetings attach a list of those who attended.
- Proofread the minutes before you submit them.
- The minutes must be checked, corrected if necessary, and approved at the next meeting. When the minutes are signed by the chairperson and note taker they become an official document.

■ Special Terms for Meetings

- Adjourn end a meeting
- Amend change or correct
- Bring to order get people's attention and start the meeting
- Convene to gather people for a meeting or start the meeting
- Table postpone a discussion to a later meeting

■ Write well: Notes About Fonts, Punctuation, & Formatting

1. Choice of Font

Choose a formal serif font such as Times New Roman.

- Avoid using Century (the default font in MSWord). Some of Century's punctuation is out of place.
- Do not use plain fonts (sans serif) such as Arial – they are too informal for minutes and reports.

2. Punctuation

Be careful to use the correct spacing for punctuation:

- There is only one space after punctuation.
- There is no space before any punctuation.

Common punctuation:

- **period** - for ending sentences.
- , **comma** - for separating words.
- ; **semi-colon** - for separating groups of words.
- : **colon** - for replacing words and ending words and sentences before a list (as above).
- () **parenthesis** (or brackets) - for extra information, not main points.

3. Formatting

Good formatting makes documents easier to read.

- Follow the format in the sample minutes and report.
- Separate paragraphs with one line. There is no need to indent at the beginning of a paragraph.
- Make sure the spacing and columns are consistent.
- Make sure the indentations are aligned.
- The space between the number and text should equal 2 spaces, not more.
- Use the Tab key to indent. Do not use the space bar.
- Add the writer's name and a line above the name for the signature.
- Include page numbers at the bottom.

■ Sample Minutes and Report

On the following pages are sample minutes and a report. They are based on the bidding team meeting in Unit 7.

- Read the minutes and report and label the parts from the list on page 27.
- Study the language and expressions used.
- Notice the similarities and differences in the language and content.

Bidding Team Meeting Minutes

Purpose Consider a construction project: Cates & Doyle Assoc.

Date August 15, 2016

Venue Project Planning Dept: Rm. C

Chair William Carr (PP Dept.)

Participants

- Steve Bates: Topic leader (Mkt. Dept.)
- Beverly Linden (Engineering Dept.)
- Michelle Tanaka (Logistics Dept.), Arrived 14:40 meeting at Dresnel
- Everett Chou Note taker (PP Dept.)

Absent Tom Mills (Finance Dept.) - sick

Meeting convened at 14:30

1. Agenda:

1. Steve Bates: Project overview; specifications, & schedule
2. McConnell's Schedule
3. Feasibility discussion & decision

2. Steve Bates presented an overview of the C&D project and distributed the specs: new contract; large contract; tight schedule: Bid deadline October 31.

3. Discussion led to the following decisions:

- a) The C&D project is feasible
- b) Steve Bates and 2 engineers will make a site inspection: Aug. 24-26.
- c) Mr. Carr will select the engineers by August 18.
- d) PP Dept. budget will finance the site inspection.
- e) Next meeting: Thursday, September 1, 10:00.

4. All items on the agenda were covered. Discussion about the Dresnel project was tabled for a separate meeting.

Meeting adjourned at 15:25.

Everett Chou / August 16, 2016

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■ Sample Report from the Bidding Team Meeting

Re: Report on the Bidding Team meeting, August 15, 2016

I attended a meeting of the inter-departmental bidding team on August 16 in PP Dept. Room C.

The chairperson, William Carr (PP Dept.), convened the meeting at 14:30. The regular team members, Steve Bates (Mkt. Dept.; Topic leader), Everett Chou (PP Dept.), Beverly Linden (Engineering Dept.), and Michelle Tanaka (Logistics Dept.), attended. Ms Tanaka arrived at 14:40 coming from a meeting at Dresnel. Tom Mills (Finance Dept.) was not able to attend as he was sick.

The purpose of the meeting was to consider the feasibility of bidding on a large construction project for a new client, Cates & Doyle Associates.

The meeting opened with Steve Bates, the topic leader, presenting C&D's specifications and schedule for the project. Mr. Bates distributed copies of the project specs to the team members. His presentation was followed by a review of McConnell's schedule and the feasibility of bidding on the project.

The main concern of the members was the large size of the project and the tight schedule. The deadline for bids is October 31 and the project must be completed within 42 months.

Through the discussion all items on the agenda were covered and several decisions were made:

1. The C&D project is feasible;
2. Steve Bates and two engineers will make a site inspection from August 24 to 26;
3. Mr. Carr will select the engineers by August 18;
4. PP Dept. budget will finance the site inspection.

Discussion about the Dresnel project was tabled for a separate meeting. Our next meeting will be after the site inspection on Thursday, September 1, at 10:00. The meeting adjourned at 15:25.

Comments: This is a very large undertaking for McConnell and it is potentially very profitable in terms of income as well as enhancing our reputation. However, the size of the project and the tight schedule are risks that we will have to manage very carefully so that this project does not exceed our capabilities and compromise our other ongoing projects. In order to successfully undertake this project McConnell will probably have to increase its resources in terms of capital and human resources.

Everett Chou / August 16, 2016

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9. Two Points of Grammar in Brief



1. At first

Avoid using “At first”. Although it is grammatically correct it is misunderstood and it is almost always used incorrectly.

“At first” is not a counter -

Count: 1, 2, 3 or First, second, third...

“At first” introduces a condition that is going to change. For example:

When I started work, at first everything was difficult because everything was new. However, as I continued to work everything got easier.

2. Agree - with, on /about, to, that

Samples

1. I agree with you. - Same thinking.
2. I agree with your comments. - Same thinking.
3. We agree on/about the need for more research. - Same thinking + noun.
4. We agreed that we had to do more research. - Same thinking + action.
5. I agree with honest business practices. - Think a principle or an idea is right.
6. We agreed on the agenda. - Decision.
7. I agree to your proposal. - Accept.
8. Our client finally agreed to the design. - Accept.
9. Mr. Suzuki agreed to present a report at the next meeting. - Accepting a requested action.
10. This food doesn't agree with me. - Makes me sick.



10. Vocabulary for Meetings



1. Vocabulary for the Chairperson

Getting people's attention

1. May I have your attention, please? (Formal: for a large meeting)
2. Alright, everybody. / OK, everybody (informal)
3. Sorry to interrupt but I think we should get started now.
4. I'd like to get started now.
5. I think we should start now.
6. Shall we start now?
7. Can we start now?
8. Shall we get down to business?
9. I think we should get down to business now.
10. Could we get down to business now?

Reviewing the agenda

1. Let's take a look at the agenda.
2. We have three items on the agenda this evening.
3. Is there anything else for the agenda?
4. Are there any other items for the agenda?
5. Does anyone have anything else for the agenda?
6. Does anyone want to add anything to the agenda?

Organizing the agenda

1. Let's start with ... and then ...
2. I think we should start with ... and then ...
3. I think our first item should be ...
4. I'd suggest we start with ... and then ...
5. Let's take a break after we finish ...
6. Mr. Ono, about how much time do you need for your presentation?

Introducing the speaker

1. Our first / next speaker is Mr. Ono.
2. Mr. Ono, would you give us your report, please?
3. Mr. Ono?

Speaker's response to the chairperson

1. Thank you, Mr. Gerrard.
2. It's my pleasure.
3. My pleasure. (Informal)
4. ... Good evening, everyone.

Conducting the discussion and moving to a decision

1. Thank you, Mr. Ono. We have time for some questions.
2. Are there any questions for Mr. Ono?
3. Are there any more questions for Mr. Ono?
4. Mr. Suzuki, do you have any questions for Mr. Ono?
5. What do you think about this, Mr. Suzuki?
6. Do you have any comments on this, Mr. Suzuki?
7. Mr. Ono, what do you think about this?
8. How do you feel about this?
(Note: "How do you think about ...?" is not correct.)
9. I'd like to get your opinion on...
10. What do you think we should do?
11. Do you all agree with this proposal?

Taking a break

1. It's time for a break. We'll begin again in 10 minutes.
2. Why don't we take a short break now? Let's start again in 10 minutes.
3. I think we should take a short break now.
4. I think it's time for a short break.
5. We'll start again at ...

Starting after a break

1. It's time to start again.
2. Shall we start again?
3. Shall we continue?
4. We'll continue with ...

Wrapping up the discussion

1. We have time for one more question.
2. If there are no more questions then we'll move on to our next item.
3. I'm sorry that's all the time we have for questions.
4. I'm sorry we're all out of time.
5. I'm sorry we have to bring this to a close.
6. I'm sorry. This is very interesting but we have to move on to our next item / the next item on our agenda.
7. Thank you everyone.
8. Thank you for a very interesting presentation, Mr. Ono.
9. That was a very informative report, Mr. Ono. Thank you very much.

2. Questions and Discussion

Introducing your question

1. I have a question.
2. Could I ask (you) a question about ...?
3. Could I ask (you) about ...?
4. I'd like to ask (you) about ...
5. I have two questions. First ... Thank you, and my second question is ...

Note: "May I have a question?" is never correct.

Questions for clarification

1. I think you said ... Is that correct?
2. I think you told us that ... Am I right?
3. Did you say ...?
4. I'm sorry. You said something about ... but I didn't understand it.
5. Did you say something about ...?

More information

1. Could you tell me more about ...?
2. I'd like to get more information about ...
3. I'm sorry. You told us about ... Could you give us some more details?

Questions to challenge and test

1. You said ... Could you tell us what you mean?
2. You said ... Could you be more specific?
3. What's the connection between A and B?
4. I'm sorry. I don't see the connection between A and B.
5. I think ... What's your opinion?
6. You said ... but don't you think that ...?

3. Responding to Questions

Pausing to think

If you need time to think about a response you must say something: Silence is rude.

1. That's an interesting question.
2. Let me see.
3. Let me think about that.

Clarifying a question

Don't try to answer a question if you don't understand it. Always ask for clarification.

1. I'm sorry. Could you repeat your question, please?
2. Could you say that again, please?
3. I'm sorry. Could you rephrase your question, please?
4. I'm sorry. I don't understand your question.

Giving a response

Avoid answering questions with just one word, “Yes” or “No”. Short blunt answers do not create an interactive atmosphere. Always expand on a simple answer.

1. Yes, that's right.
2. No. I think you may have misunderstood.
3. Let me explain.
4. I'd like to explain.
5. I'm sorry. I don't have any more information about that.

4. Responding to answers

1. I understand, thank you.
2. I see, thank you
3. I'm sorry. I'm not sure what you mean.

Offering opinions

1. I think that ...
2. I feel that ...
3. Personally, I feel / believe / think that ...
4. It seems to me that ...

5. Making Proposals

1. I think we should ...
2. Can we ...?
3. Could we ...?
4. What about this idea? ...

6. Agreeing (See the “Two Points of Grammar” for agree + with/ to/on etc.)

When you agree you should summarize the points of agreement and disagreement, and explain why.

1. I agree with you because ...
2. I agree with what you are saying because ...
3. I agree that we should ...
4. I see what you mean.
5. You've got a point.
6. You're right about that.

7. Disagreeing

1. I see what you mean, but I (still) can't agree with you. I think ...
2. I agree that something should be done, however, ...
3. I agree with your point that ... but ...
4. That's true, but ...
5. I'm afraid I'm not entirely convinced.
6. No, I don't think that's right. I think ...
7. I'm sorry, I don't agree because ...
8. I'm afraid I can't agree with you. I think ...

8. Vocabulary for Discussion

Interrupting a discussion

Sometimes it is necessary to join a conversation that you have been listening to. Be careful not to interrupt while someone is speaking. Wait until there is a pause in the conversation and then say ...

1. Excuse me. May I say something?
2. I'm sorry, may I interrupt?
3. Sorry to interrupt you but ...
4. I'd just like to say that ...
5. I'd like to add something.
6. Could I add something?

Accepting an interruption

1. Yes?
2. Certainly, go ahead.

Rejecting an interruption

1. I'm sorry, could I finish first? Then I'll answer your question.
2. Could we discuss that after I finish?
3. Could we take that up later?
4. I'm sorry, I'd like to just finish what I'm saying.



Make a difference.

Think your own thoughts. Speak your mind.



In Company
Skills & Language for Successful Staff Meetings

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